DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Did We Receive at Sinai?

Daat Tevunot §158-159

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §158 (continued; section 8, part 3) to the opening of §159 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 14 September 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

We continue on page 498, section 8, part 3, still in the middle of §158. Section 7 dealt with the emanations from outside upon the world; section 8 deals with the force that sustains existence from within. Part 1 showed that this force is double edged. Part 2 showed that God gave us free will, which makes us His partners, and that the two kinds of emanation mirror each other according to how close we are to Him.

Part 3 asks: how exactly does our doing good bring blessing into the world?

The right to serve

The Sekhel says something important first. Even though we have free will and the ability to serve Hashem, the right to serve Him exists only because He wills it. It was given to us at Har Sinai and He sustains it continuously. Our misvot have power only because God gave us the authority to do them. Without that authority they would have no effect, and might even do harm.

This, said the Rabbi, is why halachah distinguishes between someone commanded to do a misvah and someone who is not. The person who is commanded has been given authority from the Almighty, and with it the ability to rectify things in the universe.

He gave examples of how serious it is to act without authority:

- **The Kohen's garments.** When a Kohen performs the avodah, he brings about great tikkunim. But if he serves without his four garments (or the Kohen Gadol without his eight), he has the status of an outsider and is liable to death. When you overreach, you do not just fail to help; you cause damage.
- **Shabbat.** For a Jew, Shabbat is so central that breaking it is a capital offence. Yet the Gemara says that a non-Jew may not keep Shabbat in the same way. The same act has a completely different meaning depending on whether you have been given that right. (He mentioned the practice with people in the process of conversion, without going into it.)
- **Shofar.** A woman cannot blow shofar on behalf of a man, however righteous she is. She is not commanded in it, so she does not have the same power to discharge his obligation,

even though she receives reward for what she does.

What really happened at Har Sinai

The Rabbi recalled a shiur he once gave on how much Torah was actually given at Sinai: only a small part. So why is Har Sinai so central? Because of this paragraph. After the sin of Adam, humanity had lost the ability to serve God and was comparable to the animals. At Sinai, God prepared us and gave us the ability to perfect ourselves and serve Him. "You drew us near to Your great name."

This answers the famous question we ask on Pesah: what would it mean to say "had He brought us to Har Sinai and not given us the Torah, it would have been enough"? What was given at Sinai was the ability itself, the authority to do misvot and to have an effect when we do good. The rest of the Torah came over the following years.

This is the meaning of "You will be for Me a kingdom of Kohanim and a holy nation." From then on we were distinct from the nations: not because others cannot keep misvot, but because our misvot carry the power to fix the world. And this authority is renewed every day.

How the partnership works

Footnote 36 sums up: God gave man free choice, which made the righteous His partners; now we see how the partnership actually works and what is required of us.

God created evil and the darkness of the physical world, and also the ability to rectify it. He bestows shefa on the world according to how much we prepare ourselves to receive it. So it is incumbent on the righteous to rectify as much of the darkness as possible, little by little. In proportion to their work, God sends down more and more energy. In a sense, said the Rabbi, through doing good we create a new reality.

After Adam's sin the world descended and grew darker. Our task in exile is to fix what was damaged and regain what was lost, to bring the world back to where it would have been had Adam not sinned. The more we work, the more shefa descends, until the final redemption. Section 9 will explain that if it does not come through us, it will come through Hashem; but we want it to come through us.

A question about the nations

A participant suggested this might shed light on the hatred of the Jewish people: we alone were given the ability to bring down this intense shefa, and when we neglect it, it is a double blow. The Rabbi took the point seriously. As Rabbi Sacks used to write, Jews have been accused of being both capitalists and communists. The Gemara says Sinai is called Sinai because from there sinah, hatred, came down into the world.

He compared it to a pupil chosen as head boy. Others may be jealous that he got the role, but they will be far angrier if he then does not do it. "When we don't do the will of Hashem, we actually have a greater responsibility."

Twins and the two hands

The Ramhal says God has given part of His direction of the world to us. He rectifies on one side and Knesset Yisrael on the other, and together we complete it. The Rabbi brought the reading of "my dove, my perfect one" (yonati tamati) in Shir HaShirim as teomati, "my twin".

The Ramhal also brings the verse in Yeshayahu: "My hand founded the earth, and My right hand spread out the heavens." Heaven gives and earth receives, like right and left hands, but it is an equal partnership. The Rabbi compared it to a business where one partner deals with the clients and the other does the work behind the scenes. The client thinks the front man is more important, but both are equal.

He contrasted this with the "interlocking cogs" discussed months ago. That was about the system of the whole world. This is about the specific interlocking of emanation and tikkun.

The class closed by reading the opening of §159, where the Neshamah says that all this is now clear.

Summary

- Our misvot have power only because God gave us the right to do them; acting without that authority can do damage.
- What was given at Har Sinai was above all this ability and authority, which is why "bringing us to Sinai" alone would have been enough.
- God sends shefa down in proportion to how much the righteous prepare and rectify, so through doing good we create a new reality.
- God and Knesset Yisrael are partners, "twins", like the two hands: one gives and one receives, but the partnership is equal.
- Being given this role carries greater responsibility, and neglecting it is felt by the whole world.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/m2lm0F2RsNw · More shiurim: rabbikada.com